Retšelisitsoe Matlanyane

(Maht-lah-nyah-neh)

Minister of Finance & Development Planning
Kingdom of Lesotho

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Nov 2022**

Retšelisitsoe Adelai Matlanyane is a technocratic reformer who believes discipline and data-driven decisions will demonstrate Lesotho's economic potential to donors and investors.

- **Non-Partisan Professional**
  Matlanyane is proud of her technocratic background, arguing that she only entered politics to serve her country. She has insisted that she is "an economist before anything else and shall remain one."

- **Fiscal Dsciplinarian**
  Matlanyane built her reputation as Lesotho's first female Central Bank Governor by refusing monetary expansion during COVID-19, stating "we cannot substitute prudence with panic." Her fiscal conservatism has frustrated politicians seeking rapid spending increases.

Matlanyane, who presents herself as either Dr. Matlanyane or Adelai depending on the setting, is an outspoken advocate for women in leadership. She has argued that "if a woman can run a home, she can run a country."

WHY THEY MATTER

Matlanyane routinely underlines the importance of agricultural investments and climate change mitigation plans.

- **Funding Agriculture Development**
  Matlanyane has pointed to a $58 million agricultural budget allocation as a sign of her "unwavering commitment to agricultural development." She believes it has the potential to drive economic development, foster private sector-led job creation, and ensure food and nutrition security.

- **Backing Climate Smart Policies**
  Matlanyane has called for the adoption of relevant technology and advanced mechanization, including appropriate seed and fertilizer inputs, as well as climate smart technologies to increase the yield of basic grains, legumes, vegetables and deciduous crops.

Matlanyane sees her government work as service to her nation, explaining that "sustainable development is not merely a technical issue; it is a moral imperative that underpins our shared vision of a world free from poverty, inequality, and environmental degradation."

MEETING WITH THEM

Matlanyane, while courteous in her engagements and careful when explaining her position, will overwhelm counterparts with facts and figures to make her point. She is not above a fiery riposte when she disagrees or is displeased.

- **Anchoring in Evidence**
  She presents counterparts with specific fiscal metrics and insights from econometric models. Proposals with robust data and measurable outcomes engage her, while vague pitches meet polite disinterest.

- **Rejecting Impropriety**
  She lashes out when she deems questions to be inappropriate or asked in an unprofessional manner. She vented her frustration when a journalist called her at 5 am, saying "I am the one who called you so listen to me. Please respect me like I respect you."

In an interview with a local newspaper in late 2022, she bristled at being called a politician and denounced "the fact that politics have come to be viewed as an easy aperture and a lucrative career by those who have failed to build a career for themselves to get into public administration."

ON THEIR MIND

- **IMF Report**
  The IMF in mid-October said Lesotho must overhaul its economic model to unlock private sector–led job creation to end chronic unemployment and poverty. In its report, the IMF projected a 1.4 percent increase in real GDP in 2025.

- **U.S. Trade Policy**
  Lesotho has been devastated by the imposition of a 15 percent U.S. tariff and the expiration of the African Growth and Opportunity Act; textile exports to the United States accounts for around 10 percent of GDP.

- **Opposition Pressure**
  The opposition Democratic Congress (DC) in mid-October called for all state loans to be approved by parliament to rein in the country's massive public debt.

- **RSL Controversy**
  The Revenue Services Lesotho (RSL)'s Board of Directors in mid-October says it is intervening to try and resolve the escalating feud between Matlanyane and the RSL Commissioner-General.

NETWORK

Widely respected for her competence and expertise, Matlanyane is trying to leverage her credentials to manage ties with the United States and deepen relations with the UN, World Bank, African Development Bank, European Union, China, and Gulf.

She expressed “relief” that the United States had lowered its tariffs from 50 to 15 percent on Lesotho, but remains concerned about its impact and the likely cancellation of a Millennium Challenge Compact. USAID’s dismantling has been devastating to Lesotho’s health sector, setting the country back 15 years according to one expert.

Matlanyane is a relative newcomer to Basotho politics, seeking to build her political network while guarding her authority and control over the country’s purse strings.

Matlanyne is quick to say that she is one of the founders of the ruling Revolution for Prosperity (RFP), which came to power for the first time in its history. She portrays herself as an outsider, like Prime Minister Sam Matekane, who can inject dynamism in the government, but has struggled with the challenges of navigating national politics.

CONTROVERSIES

While largely untainted by personal scandal, Matlanyane faces criticism for controlling behavior around transparency mechanisms and bureaucratic overreach.

- **RSL Tax Clash**
  In September 2025, Revenue Services Lesotho's boss made "explosive claims" that Matlanyane issued unlawful instructions regarding confidential taxpayer information and data manipulation—serious allegations of ministerial overreach that remain unresolved.

- **Bureaucratic Friction**
  Parliamentary opposition characterizes her as "starving development projects" through excessive fiscal caution, while business associations criticize payment arrears to government suppliers that she publicly acknowledged, but has failed to resolve.

Some critics have said her agenda lacks ambition and have issued a poor report card on her performance. One website judged that “we think she can do better too, if she can manage to calm herself down, listen and answer questions like the professional she is.”

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Finance & Development Planning**, Kingdom of Lesotho (2022 - present)
- **Governor & Chair of the Board**, Central Bank of Lesotho (2012 to 2021)
- **First Deputy Governor**, Central Bank of Lesotho (2007 to 2012)
- **Second Deputy Governor**, Central Bank of Lesotho (2006 to 2007)
- **Lecturer in Economics**, National University of Lesotho (2005 to 2006)

BIO

Matlanyane escaped rural poverty through academic excellence, rising from her village roots to break gender barriers and become Lesotho's most influential economic policymaker. Born in Mafeteng, the Minister is one of eight children raised in a household where parents treated education as "sacred."

- **Making the Grade**
  Matlanyane earned her PhD in Economics from the University of Pretoria, specializing in macroeconometric modeling. Her Master's came from the University of Botswana and Bachelor's from the National University of Lesotho, where she later taught before joining public service.

- **Breaking the Glass Ceiling**
  As Lesotho's first female Central Bank Governor, she often talks about the role of women in politics and national life. She is also unapologetic about her appearance, recently taking heat from the opposition for wearing a tight beige suit that "exposed her curviness" in parliament, according to local press.

Matlanyane occasionally references her role as wife and mother of two. She reads academic and economics books, even providing a blurb for former colleague (and Kenyan Central Bank Governor) Patrick Njoroge. She speaks fluent Sesotho and English.